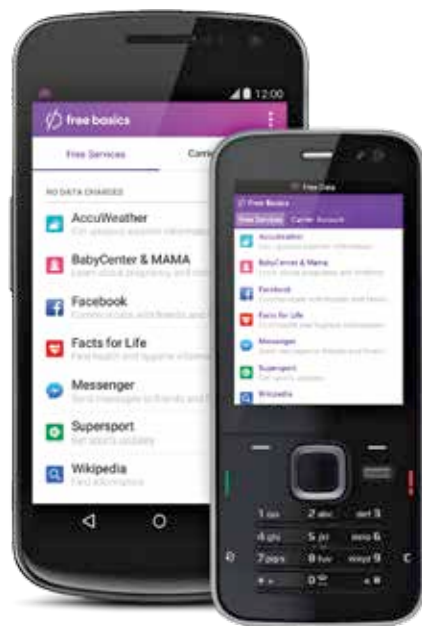


where you connect from, we will have several different Internet “islands” that provide gated access to services to serve vested interests, as Net Neutrality proponents have alleged. Case in point: Free Basics.

WHAT IS FREE BASICS?

What was earlier Internet.org, Free Basics is Facebook’s effort to connect as many people who aren’t online (heck, who haven’t even heard of the Internet in the first place!) to the Internet. Facebook is tying up with telcos (Reliance Communications in India) around the world (Africa, South America, etc) to provide “basic” Internet services like Wikipedia, ESPN Cricinfo, Bing Search, BBC, Aaj Tak, etc. A noble cause, right? If Mark Zuckerberg wants to connect the next billion people online without charging them a dime, what’s so wrong? And why isn’t everyone applauding the effort?

Only because Free Basics is directly in conflict with Net Neutrality principles. As it exists now, Free Basics is discriminating against services and prioritising one service over others. For instance, under Free Basics, users will have access to Facebook and Facebook Messenger but not WhatsApp or Telegram, Bing but not Google, OLX but not Quikr, and so on. Facebook



Free Basics: Greater good?

is controlling which services to offer and not everyone is fully convinced it’s due to the largesse of its founder’s philanthropic heart. The move is also anti-competition and monopolistic in nature.

The greater damage caused by Free Basics, according to Net Neutrality proponents, is the people who access the service

may end up experiencing a curtailed version of the Internet and not realise its full potential. This will essentially carve up the Internet into several small islands, which is detrimental to the Internet as a whole.

TRAI is tasked with hearing both sides of the debate and finalize the Net Neutrality principles as it’s best applicable in the Indian context. So far, TRAI has received over a million emails asking it to uphold Net Neutrality principles in its entirety with no compromise over differential pricing of OTT (over-the-top services, which is how most Internet traffic is categorized) and certainly walled Internet gardens (like Free Basics). Is this the right approach to connect hundreds of millions of impoverished Indians online in the quickest possible manner?

What we need to decide and decide quickly is the following: Are these corporate efforts out to fracture the very ethos of a wide, uninterrupted, bottomless expanse of the Internet as it exists now? Can the net truly be neutral? What needs to be protected and what needs to be implemented? What are we fighting for here? The consequences of our actions may alter the very fabric of the Internet. It may never be the same from this point on. **[1]**

DEMON

How Facebook will kill the Internet

BY MITHUN MOHANDAS

The easiest part of a Net Neutrality debate is where you list out the cons, the wrongs, the evils. Basically, everything negative about a non-neutral entity. Simply put, this story was the easiest to write. Not only because it is the right stance on the issue

but Facebook, through its actions over the past few months has done its fair share towards driving nails into its own coffin.

WHAT FB IS OFFERING?

If you’ve read through the first article in this cover story then you now know what

Net Neutrality is and why it is important. And like everything under the sun, the definition of Net Neutrality has been interpreted differently by different parties to further their own cause. Facebook, despite creating a walled garden considers Free-Basics to adhere to their interpretation